Chapter-Six
Personality and Values

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Definition of Personality

- An individual's personality is a unique combination of emotional, thought, and behavioral patterns that affect how a person react to situations and interacts with others. It's our natural way of doing things and relating to others. Personality is most often described in terms of measurable traits a person exhibits.
- Over the years, researchers have attempted to identify, those traits that best describe personality. The two most well-known approaches are the Myers-Briggs Type Indicators (MBTI) and the Big Five Model.

Personality Determinants

An early debate centered on whether an indibidual's personality is the result of heredity or environment. Personality appears to be a result of both; however, research tends to support the importance of heredity over environment.

- Heredity
- Environment

❖ **Heredity:** Heredity refers to factors determined at conception. Physical stature, facial features, gender, temperament, muscle composition and reflexes, energy level and biological rhythms are either completely and substantially influenced by parentage – by your biological parents, physiological, and inherent psychological makeup.

Personality Determinants

- This is not to suggest that personality never changes. People's scores on dependability tend to increase over time, as when young adults start families and establish careers.
- **Environment:** Personality is not solely determined by genetic characteristics. Heredity provides only the blueprint in terms of chromosomes and genes. However, the ability to operate on that gene is largely dependent on the presence of a suitable environment. For example, a person may have mathematical ability but this ability cannot be refined unless that person is provided with the opportunity to exercise his ability for math's.
- Social Factors
- Cultural Factors
- Economic Factors

Personality Determinants

- **Social Factors:** Human beings are social animals. We are born and brought up in society. Therefore, social conditions, social institutions – family, school, marriage, religion, peer groups and neighborhood as well as various other social groups will all affect the development of personality.
- **Cultural Factors:** Culture is a comprehensive phrase that encompasses all practices, traditions, people, styles, fads, and other aspects of life. We are all influenced by one or more cultures. As a result, a cultural impact on personality is unavoidable.
- **Economic Factors:** It was demonstrated that our attitude and perception, as well as our personality, are influenced by economic factors. You may have noticed that children from low-income families frequently have low self-confidence, feelings of inferiority, and shyness.

Myers-Briggs Type Indicators (MBTI)

- One popular approach to classifying personality traits is the personality-assessment instrument known as the MBTI. This 100-question assessment ask people how they usually act or feel in different situations. On the basis of their answers, individuals are classified as exhibiting a preference in four categories. These are-
- Extraversion or Introversion (E or I)
- Sensing or Intuition (S or N)
- Thinking or Feeling (T or F)
- Judging or Perceiving (J or P)

Myers-Briggs Type Indicators (MBTI)

- **Extraversion (E) Versus Introversion (I):** Individuals showing a preference for extraversion are outgoing, social, and assertive. They need a work environment that's varied and action oriented, that lets them be with others, and that gives them a variety of experiences. Individual showing a preference for introversion are quiet and shy. They focus on understanding and prefer a work environment that is quiet and concentrated, that lets them be alone, and that gives them a chance to explore in depth a limited set of experiences.

Myers-Briggs Type Indicators (MBTI)

- **Sensing (S) Versus Intuition (N):** Sensing types are practical and prefer routine and order. They dislike new problems unless there are standard ways to solve them, have a high need for closure, show patience with routine details, and tend to be good at precise work. On the other hand, intuition types rely on unconscious processes and look at the ‘big picture’. They are individuals who like solving problems, dislike doing the same thing over and over again, jump to conclusions, are impatient with routine details, and dislike taking time for precision.

Myers-Briggs Type Indicators (MBTI)

- **Thinking (T) Versus Feeling (F):** Thinking types use reason and logic to handle problems. They are unemotional and uninterested in people's feelings, like analysis and putting things into logical order, are able to reprimand people and fire them when necessary, may seem hard-hearted, and tend to relate well only to other thinking types. Feeling types rely on their personal values and emotions. They are aware of other people and their feelings, like harmony, need occasional praise, dislike telling people unpleasant thinks, tend to be sympathetic, and relate well to most people.

Myers-Briggs Type Indicators (MBTI)

- **Judging (J) Versus Perceiving (P):** Judging types want to control and prefer their world to be ordered and structured. They are good planners, decisive, purposeful, and exacting. They focus on completing a task , make decisions quickly, and want only the information necessary to get a task done. Perceiving types are flexible and spontaneous. They are curious, adaptable, and tolerant. They focus on starting a task, postpone decisions, and want to find out all about the task before starting it.

The BIG Five Model

In recent years, research has shown that five basic personality dimensions underlie all others and encompass most of the significant variation in human personality. The five personality traits in the **BIG Five Model** are-

- **Extraversion:** The extraversion dimension captures our relational approach toward the social world. Extraverts tend to be gregarious, assertive, and sociable. They experience more positive emotions than do introverts, and they more freely express their feelings.
- **Agreeableness:** The agreeableness dimensions refers to an individual's propensity to defer to others. Agreeable people are more cooperative, warm, and trusting. You might expect agreeable people to be happier than disagreeable people.

The BIG Five Model

- **Conscientiousness:** The degree to which someone is reliable, responsible, dependable, persistent, and achievement oriented. A highly conscientious person is responsible, organized, dependable, and persistent. Those who score low on this dimension are easily distracted, disorganized, and unreliable.
- **Emotional Stability:** The degree to which someone is calm, enthusiastic, and secure (positive) or tense, nervous, depressed, and insecure (negative). The emotional stability dimension taps a person's ability to withstand stress.
- **Openness to Experience:** The degree to which someone has a wide range of interests and is imaginative, fascinated with novelty, artistically sensitive, and intellectual. Open people are creative, curious, and artistically sensitive.

The BIG Five Model

- The BIG Five Model provides more than just a personality framework. Research has shown that important relationship exist between these personality dimensions and job performance. For example, extraversion predicted performance in managerial and sales positions – occupations in which high social interaction necessary. Another study that looked at whether the five factor-model could predict managerial performance found it could if 360-degree performance ratings (that is, performance ratings from supervisors, peers, and subordinates) were used.

Additional Personality Insights

Although the traits in the Big Five are highly relevant to understanding behavior, they aren't the only personality traits that can describe someone's personality. Five other personality traits are powerful predictors of behavior in organizations.

- **Locus of Control:** Some people believe they control their own fate. Others see themselves as pawns, believing that what happens to them in their lives is due to luck or chance. The locus of control in the first case is internal; these people believe they control their own destiny. The locus of control in the second case is external; these people believe their lives are controlled by outside forces.

Additional Personality Insights

- **Machiavellianism:** The second characteristics is called Machiavellianism (Mach), named after Niccolo Machiavelli, who wrote in the sixteenth century on how to gain and manipulate power. An individual high in Machiavellianism is pragmatic, maintains emotional distance, and believes that ends can justify means. In jobs that require bargaining skills or that have substantial rewards for excelling, high Machs are productive.
- **Self-Esteem:** People differ in the degree to which they like or dislike themselves, a trait called self-esteem. Research on self-esteem (SE) offers some interesting behavioral insights. For example, self-esteem is directly related to expectations for success. Those high in SE believe they possess the ability they need to succeed at work. Individuals with high SEs will take more risks in job selection and are more likely to choose unconventional jobs than people with low SE.

Additional Personality Insights

- **Self-Monitoring :** Self-monitoring is a personality trait that measures the ability to adjust behavior to external situational factors. Individuals high in self-monitoring show considerable adaptability in adjusting their behavior. They are highly sensitive to external cues and can behave differently in different situations. High self-monitors are capable of presenting striking contradictions between their public persona and their private selves. Low self-monitors can't adjust their behavior.
- **Risk-Taking:** People differ in their willingness to take chances. Differences in the propensity to assume or to avoid risk have been shown to affect how long it takes managers to make a decision and how much information they require before making a choice. For instance, in one study where managers worked on simulated exercises that require them to make hiring decisions, high risk-taking managers took less time to make decisions and used less information in making their choices than low risk-taking managers.

Values

- Values represent basic convictions that a specific mode of conduct or end state of existence is personally or socially preferable to an opposite or converse mode of conduct or end-state of existence. Values contain a judgmental element because they carry an individual's ideas about what is right, good, or desirable. They have both content and intensity attributes.
- Values tend to be relatively stable and enduring. Many of the values we hold are established in our early years – by parents, teachers, friends and others. If we question values, they may change, but more often they are reinforced. There is also evidence linking personality to values, implying our values may be partly determined by genetically transmitted traits.

Cultural Values (Hofstede's Framework)

- Unlike personality, which is largely genetically determined, values are learned. They are passed down through generations and vary by cultures. One of the most widely referenced approaches for analyzing variations among cultures was done in the late 1970s by Geert Hofstede. Hofstede surveyed more than 116,000 IBM employees in 40 countries about their work- related values and found that managers and employees varied on five value dimensions of national culture:

- Power distance
- Individualism versus collectivism
- Masculinity versus femininity
- Uncertainty avoidance
- Long-term versus short-term orientation

Cultural Values (Hofstede's Framework)

- **Power Distance:** Power distance describes the degree to which people in a country accept that power in institutions and organizations is distributed unequally. A high rating on power distance means large inequalities of power and wealth exist and are tolerated in the culture, as in a class or caste system that discourages upward mobility.
- **Individualism Versus Collectivism:** Individualism is the degree to which people prefer to act as individuals rather than as members of groups and believe in an individual's rights above all else. Collectivism emphasizes a tight social framework in which people expect others in groups of which they are a part to look after them and protect them.

Cultural Values (Hofstede's Framework)

- **Masculinity Versus Femininity:** Hofstede's construct of masculinity is the degree to which the cultures favors traditional masculine roles such as achievement, power, and control, as opposed to viewing men and women as equals. A high masculinity rating indicates the culture has separate roles for men and women, with men dominating the society.
- **Uncertainty Avoidance:** The degree to which people in a country prefer structured over unstructured situations defines their uncertainty avoidance. In cultures scoring high on uncertainty avoidance, people have increased anxiety about uncertainty and ambiguity and use laws and controls to reduce uncertainty. People in cultures low on uncertainty avoidance are more accepting of ambiguity, are less rule oriented, take more risks, and accept change more rapidly.

Cultural Values (Hofstede's Framework)

- **Long-term Versus Short-term Orientations:** This typology measures a society's devotion to traditional values. People in a culture with long-term orientation look to the future and value thrift, persistence, and tradition. In a short-term orientation, people value the here and now, they also accept change more readily and don't see commitments as impediments to change.

END OF CHAPTER

HAVE A GOOD DAY